

BANDEEP SINGH



From genre-defying genius to joker, from shock meister to schlock purveyor, when did the wizard of the dark arts lose his mojo? Long before his two most recent movies, *Aag* and *Darling*.

THE UNMAKING OF

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Ask him how he feels about being forced to vacate his plush Andy Warhol-esque The Factory office by his former financiers K Sera Sera—where he would be mobbed by newcomers angling for a break—to a nondescript workplace in a shopping complex and he swats it away with more than a trace of irritation. “I live in my mind,” says the 45-year old Ram Gopal Varma imperiously. Just as well. After two successive turkeys, the modestly titled *Ram Gopal Varma ki Aag* and the horror comedy *Darling*, he certainly doesn’t live in the hearts and minds of the audience. The man who patented Bollywood’s dark arts is, by his own admission, feeling “burnt and charred”, a victim of his previous success.

For if anyone typifies Bollywood’s inability to cope with its newly-acquired corporate status, it is Varma. A talented filmmaker lured into transforming himself into a brand, a sharp director tempted to turn into an industrial house,

Varma went from making movies to planning proposals. The man who once launched Vivek Oberoi in a secondary role in *Company* in 2002 now propels blocks of wood like Mohit Ahlawat (and manages to fall out even with him), the fan who once worshipped Sridevi (and directed her in the Telugu *Kshana Kshanam* in 1991) now promotes Nisha Kothari, and the filmmaker who once tickled cinemagoers with immortal lines such as “*apna to bad luck hi kharab hai*” in *Rangeela* in 1995 now writes such eternal dialogues as *Aag*’s “*Don’t judge a book by the cover, I’m your lover*”.

Perhaps like all auteurs, Varma’s greatest creation may have been himself. The son of a sound engineer who worked closely with actor Nagarjuna’s father, A. Nageswara Rao, Varma is a Vijayawada engineering college dropout, whose real love was the movies he watched as a video library owner in Hyderabad—but when he came to Mumbai, he almost instantly found himself an iconic filmmaker after *Rangeela*. He also began a mutually beneficial relationship with the media, where his grandiloquent pronouncements routinely made